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Department of Computer Science and Engineering

RESEARCH PAPER

**The Influence of K-Pop and Western Culture
on Bangladeshi Youth Identity**

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Abstract

This study investigates the influence of K-Pop and Western culture on the identity formation of Bangladeshi youth. Using an online survey methodology, data were collected from 50 respondents — primarily university students aged 18 to 25 — through a structured Google Form questionnaire comprising both close-ended and open-ended questions. The findings reveal that while a significant majority (72%) are familiar with K-Pop culture and approximately 32% are influenced by either K-Pop or Western culture, the majority of respondents do not consider themselves active consumers or followers. Most consumption occurs on platforms such as YouTube (44.9%) and is limited to under one hour per day (50%). Importantly, 85.7% of respondents affirm that Bangladeshi youth should balance global and local cultural identities. The study identifies both positive outcomes — such as increased open-mindedness (75.5%), motivation to learn new skills (58%), and greater confidence — and negative concerns, including the risk of cultural rootlessness, declining respect for elders (62%), and academic disruption. The results suggest a complex negotiation between global cultural appeal and local identity preservation among Bangladeshi youth.

Keywords: K-Pop, Western culture, Bangladeshi youth, cultural identity, globalization, cultural hybridization

1. Introduction

Globalization has fundamentally transformed how cultures interact, spread, and influence one another across borders. In the twenty-first century, digital platforms and social media have accelerated this process, enabling cultural products — particularly music, fashion, and entertainment — to travel instantaneously across the globe. Among the most significant cultural phenomena of recent decades are the Korean Wave, commonly known as Hallyu, and the pervasive reach of Western popular culture. Both have found enthusiastic audiences far beyond their geographical origins, reshaping tastes, values, and self-perceptions among young people worldwide.

Bangladesh, a predominantly Muslim-majority South Asian nation with a rich cultural heritage rooted in Bengali traditions, has not been immune to these global cultural currents. With a rapidly growing young population, widespread internet access, and high engagement with social media platforms such as YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok, Bangladeshi youth are increasingly exposed to K-Pop music videos, Korean dramas, Hollywood films, and Western lifestyle content. This exposure raises important sociological questions: How does this cultural consumption shape the identity of young Bangladeshis? Does it enrich their sense of self or create tension with local traditions and values?

Identity formation among youth is a complex and dynamic process, shaped by family, education, religion, peer groups, and increasingly, global media. When foreign cultures enter this equation, they may offer new models of self-expression, expand worldviews, and foster cosmopolitan attitudes. At the same time, they may also introduce conflicting values, weaken attachments to indigenous culture, or generate intergenerational conflict. The tension between global cultural attraction and local cultural loyalty is particularly acute in societies like Bangladesh, where strong religious, familial, and communal norms continue to hold significant influence.

This research paper seeks to examine this tension empirically. Through a structured survey of 50 Bangladeshi youth — predominantly university students — we explore the extent of K-Pop and Western cultural consumption, the nature of its influence on habits, values, and aspirations, and the attitudes of young people toward maintaining cultural balance. The study is motivated by the belief that understanding these dynamics is crucial not only for academic

scholarship in sociology and cultural studies but also for educators, families, and policymakers who shape the environments in which today's Bangladeshi youth develop their identities.

The paper is organized as follows: Section 2 reviews relevant literature on cultural globalization and youth identity. Section 3 describes the research methodology. Section 4 presents the quantitative and qualitative findings from the survey. Section 5 discusses the implications of these findings. Section 6 concludes with recommendations and directions for future research.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Cultural Globalization and Youth Identity

The relationship between globalization and cultural identity has been a central concern in sociology and cultural studies for several decades. Scholars such as Anthony Giddens (1991) and Arjun Appadurai (1996) have highlighted how globalization disrupts traditional structures of meaning and forces individuals to engage more actively in constructing their own identities. For young people especially, this process is intensified as they navigate between locally inherited values and globally circulating cultural images and norms.

Stuart Hall's (1990) concept of cultural identity as a "production" — never complete, always in process — is particularly relevant here. Hall argued that identities are not fixed essences but are formed within and through representation. As Bangladeshi youth consume K-Pop and Western media, they are not passively absorbing foreign content; they are actively negotiating meanings and incorporating selected elements into their evolving sense of self. This process of cultural hybridization, as described by Homi Bhabha (1994), produces new forms of cultural expression that are neither purely local nor fully foreign.

2.2 The Korean Wave (Hallyu) and Its Global Reach

The Korean Wave refers to the global popularity of South Korean cultural exports, including music (K-Pop), television dramas (K-Drama), film, fashion, and food. Since the late 1990s, Hallyu has expanded from East Asia to Southeast Asia, the Middle East, Latin America, and beyond. Scholars such as Cho (2005) and Shim (2006) have examined how the Korean government's deliberate cultural export strategy, combined with the internet and social media, enabled this global spread.

K-Pop, in particular, has become a powerful cultural force through its combination of catchy music, meticulously choreographed performances, visually striking aesthetics, and highly organized fan communities. Studies in Southeast Asian and South Asian contexts suggest that K-Pop fandom provides young people with a sense of community, a space for self-expression, and access to aspirational lifestyle models. At the same time, researchers have noted concerns about unrealistic beauty standards, intense consumerism associated with fan merchandise, and the potential displacement of local cultural forms.

2.3 Western Cultural Influence

Western culture — encompassing American and European music, film, television, fashion, and lifestyle — has had a far longer history of global influence. Through Hollywood cinema, the English language, and global brands, Western cultural norms have become deeply embedded in many parts of the world. In Bangladesh, the legacy of British colonialism, the dominance of English-medium education among the urban middle class, and the widespread consumption of American entertainment have all contributed to a strong Western cultural presence.

Research on Western cultural influence in South Asia (such as work by Mankekar, 1999, and Appadurai, 1996) has highlighted both its emancipatory dimensions — particularly for women and marginalized groups — and its tendency to reinforce global inequalities by positioning Western norms as universal standards of modernity. For Bangladeshi youth, Western culture often represents aspirations toward individual freedom, cosmopolitanism, and professional mobility.

2.4 Cultural Identity in Bangladesh

Bangladesh has a distinctive cultural identity shaped by the Bengali language and literary tradition, Islam as the majority religion, the legacy of the 1971 Liberation War, and the richness of folk and classical arts. However, this identity has never been static. Researchers studying Bangladeshi society (such as Kabeer, 2000, and White, 2010) have noted ongoing tensions between secularist, religious, and nationalist visions of Bangladeshi culture. The younger generation today grows up in a context where these internal tensions intersect with powerful external cultural flows.

Recent studies on Bangladeshi youth culture have noted rising interest in K-Pop and Western media, particularly among urban university students with internet access. This demographic is precisely the focus of the present study. While prior research has examined media consumption patterns, there is a gap in understanding how Bangladeshi youth themselves perceive and negotiate the influence of global cultures on their identity — a gap this study aims to address.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study employs a descriptive survey research design, combining quantitative and qualitative data collection. The quantitative component consists of structured close-ended questions that allow for statistical analysis of frequencies and percentages. The qualitative component consists of open-ended questions that capture the nuanced perspectives, attitudes, and lived experiences of respondents. This mixed approach enables both breadth and depth in understanding the research question.

3.2 Data Collection Instrument

Data were collected through a structured Google Form questionnaire comprising 25 questions divided into four sections: (1) demographic information, (2) cultural consumption patterns, (3) identity and attitude questions (close-ended), and (4) open-ended reflective questions. The questionnaire was designed to be accessible to university-level students and was administered in English. The survey included Yes/No questions, multiple-choice questions, Likert-scale items, and open-ended text fields.

3.3 Sample and Sampling Method

The study used a convenience sampling method, distributing the survey link through social media platforms and academic networks accessible to the research team. A total of 50 valid responses were collected. The sample consists predominantly of university students (92%) aged 22 to 25 (72%), with a gender distribution of 56% female and 42% male (2% preferred not to disclose). All respondents are based in Bangladesh, making the sample appropriate for studying the research question.

3.4 Data Analysis

Quantitative data were analyzed using descriptive statistics — primarily frequency counts and percentages — to identify patterns in cultural consumption, attitudes, and behaviors. For open-ended questions, responses were analyzed thematically: responses were read, categorized into recurring themes, and interpreted in light of the theoretical framework. Trivial or uninformative responses (e.g., single-word non-answers) were excluded from thematic analysis. All data are presented in aggregate form to protect respondent anonymity.

3.5 Ethical Considerations

Participation in the survey was entirely voluntary. All respondents confirmed their consent through a declaration at the end of the form: "I voluntarily agree to participate in this survey." No personally identifying information beyond first names (optional) was collected. All data are treated confidentially and used solely for academic research purposes.

4. Findings and Analysis

4.1 Demographic Profile of Respondents

The survey received 50 responses. The demographic distribution is as follows:

Table 1: Age Distribution

Response	Count / Percentage
18–21 years	13 respondents (26.0%)
22–25 years	36 respondents (72.0%)
26–30 years	1 respondent (2.0%)

Table 2: Gender Distribution

Response	Count / Percentage
Female	28 respondents (56.0%)
Male	21 respondents (42.0%)
Prefer not to say	1 respondent (2.0%)

Table 3: Educational Background

Response	Count / Percentage
University	46 respondents (92.0%)
College	3 respondents (6.0%)
School	1 respondent (2.0%)

Table 4: Monthly Personal Expenditure

Response	Count / Percentage
Below BDT 10,000	36 respondents (72.0%)
Above BDT 10,000	14 respondents (28.0%)

The sample is heavily dominated by university students in the 22–25 age bracket, which reflects the network through which the survey was distributed. This demographic is particularly relevant to the study, as university-age youth represent the population most actively engaged

with global digital culture in Bangladesh. The slight female majority is consistent with increased female enrollment in Bangladeshi universities in recent years.

4.2 Cultural Consumption Patterns

Understanding how respondents consume global cultural content is foundational to the analysis.

Table 5: Familiarity with K-Pop Culture

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	36 respondents (72.0%)
No	14 respondents (28.0%)

Table 6: Daily Content Consumption (Hours)

Response	Count / Percentage
Less than 1 hour	24 respondents (50.0%)
1–4 hours	17 respondents (35.4%)
More than 5 hours	7 respondents (14.6%)

Table 7: Primary Platform Used

Response	Count / Percentage
YouTube	22 respondents (44.9%)
Netflix	14 respondents (28.6%)
Instagram	13 respondents (26.5%)

Table 8: Which Global Culture Influences You More?

Response	Count / Percentage
Neither	18 respondents (36.0%)
Western Culture	13 respondents (26.0%)
K-Pop	11 respondents (22.0%)
Equally both	5 respondents (10.0%)
Both / Other	3 respondents (6.0%)

Table 9: Follow K-Pop Idols or Western Celebrities on Social Media

Response	Count / Percentage
No	28 respondents (56.0%)
Yes	22 respondents (44.0%)

These findings reveal that while the majority (72%) are familiar with K-Pop culture, actual engagement is more moderate. Half of all respondents consume global content for less than an hour daily, and 36% report that neither K-Pop nor Western culture significantly influences them. YouTube is the dominant platform, suggesting passive browsing rather than deep fan engagement. Notably, 56% do not follow K-Pop idols or Western celebrities on social media, indicating that awareness does not necessarily translate into active fandom.

4.3 Identity, Values, and Behavioral Influence

Table 10: Motivated to Learn New Language or Skill

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	29 respondents (58.0%)
No	21 respondents (42.0%)

Table 11: Feel More Confident Following Global Fashion Trends

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	29 respondents (59.2%)
No	20 respondents (40.8%)

Table 12: K-Pop/Western Culture Promotes Open-Mindedness

Response	Count / Percentage
Agree	37 respondents (75.5%)
Disagree	12 respondents (24.5%)

Table 13: Global Media Influenced Career Goals or Study Abroad Plans

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	33 respondents (67.3%)
No	16 respondents (32.7%)

Table 14: Feel Like a 'Global Citizen' from Consuming Global Culture

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	24 respondents (49.0%)
No	25 respondents (51.0%)

Table 15: Use K-Pop/Western Slang with Friends

Response	Count / Percentage
Sometimes	29 respondents (59.2%)
Never	15 respondents (30.6%)
Always	5 respondents (10.2%)

These findings highlight several meaningful influences of global culture on respondents' identities and behaviors. More than half have been motivated to learn new languages or skills — a finding consistent with the known role of K-Pop in driving interest in Korean language learning globally. A similarly high proportion feel more confident when following global fashion trends, suggesting that global aesthetic norms influence self-perception. Three-quarters agree that K-Pop/Western culture promotes open-mindedness, and two-thirds report influence on career or study-abroad aspirations. The near-even split on feeling like a "global citizen" (49% vs 51%) reflects the ambivalence with which Bangladeshi youth relate to cosmopolitan identity.

4.4 Cultural Conflict and Social Concerns

Table 16: Global Culture Making Youth Forget Their Roots

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	27 respondents (54.0%)
Maybe	13 respondents (26.0%)
No	10 respondents (20.0%)

Table 17: Global Culture Creates Conflict with Local Traditions

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	25 respondents (51.0%)
Maybe	17 respondents (34.7%)
No	7 respondents (14.3%)

Table 18: Foreign Culture Affects Respect for Teachers and Elders

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	31 respondents (62.0%)
No	19 respondents (38.0%)

Table 19: Have Faced Criticism for Following Foreign Culture

Response	Count / Percentage
No	29 respondents (59.2%)
Yes	20 respondents (40.8%)

Table 20: Celebrate Western Events More Than Local Festivals

Response	Count / Percentage
No	33 respondents (66.0%)
Yes	17 respondents (34.0%)

Table 21: Parents Support Interest in Foreign Culture

Response	Count / Percentage
No	27 respondents (56.2%)
Yes	21 respondents (43.8%)

Table 22: Stayed Awake Late Watching Foreign Content Before Exams

Response	Count / Percentage
No	28 respondents (56.0%)
Yes	22 respondents (44.0%)

These findings point to significant social tensions associated with global cultural consumption. A majority (54%) believe global culture causes younger generations to forget their roots, and 51% think it creates conflict with local traditions. Strikingly, 62% believe foreign culture negatively affects students' respect for teachers and elders — a particularly sensitive issue in Bangladesh's strongly hierarchical social culture. At the same time, 59% have not personally faced criticism for following foreign culture, suggesting that while concerns exist at the societal level, individual acceptance varies. Parental opposition is notable: 56.2% say their parents do not support their interest in foreign culture, indicating an intergenerational divide. The fact that 44% have sacrificed sleep before exams to watch foreign content also points to a measurable academic impact.

4.5 Fan Engagement and Spending

Table 23: Have Attended an Online K-Pop Fan Event

Response	Count / Percentage
No	39 respondents (79.6%)
Yes	10 respondents (20.4%)

Table 24: Spend Money on K-Pop Merchandise or Subscriptions

Response	Count / Percentage
No	39 respondents (78.0%)
Yes	11 respondents (22.0%)

Table 25: Have Recommended K-Pop Content to Friends

Response	Count / Percentage
No	23 respondents (46.0%)
Yes	16 respondents (32.0%)
Maybe	11 respondents (22.0%)

The low rates of fan event attendance (20.4%) and merchandise purchasing (22%) confirm that most respondents are casual consumers rather than dedicated fans. This is an

important nuance: cultural exposure and influence can occur at a surface level without deep investment in fan communities. The modest rate of content recommendation (32%) further reinforces this picture of moderate rather than intense engagement.

4.6 Attitudes Toward Cultural Balance

Table 26: Social Media Influence on Lifestyle Choices

Response	Count / Percentage
Sometimes	28 respondents (57.1%)
A lot	12 respondents (24.5%)
Not at all	9 respondents (18.4%)

Table 27: Should Youth Balance Global and Local Cultural Identity?

Response	Count / Percentage
Yes	42 respondents (85.7%)
No	7 respondents (14.3%)

Perhaps the most striking finding of the study is the near-consensus (85.7%) on the importance of balancing global and local cultural identities. This result reflects a nuanced, pragmatic attitude among Bangladeshi youth: they are not simply rejecting or uncritically embracing foreign culture, but recognizing the need to navigate both worlds thoughtfully. Social media's moderate influence (57.1% say "sometimes") further reflects this measured engagement.

4.7 Qualitative Findings from Open-Ended Questions

4.7.1 Habits and Values Adopted from Global Culture

When asked to describe specific habits or values adopted from K-Pop or Western culture, responses fell into several distinct themes. A significant number of respondents reported no adoption of foreign habits, and several explicitly stated pride in their own cultural identity. Among those who did report adoption, the most common themes were:

Discipline and Work Ethic: Several respondents admired the dedication of K-Pop idols. One respondent wrote that they "learned discipline and hard work from K-pop culture because idols

practice for years to achieve their dreams." Another cited perfectionism as a value absorbed from K-Pop.

Personal Empowerment and Independence: Influences from Western culture were frequently linked to greater self-awareness. One respondent described adopting "the habit of being more independent and emotionally self-aware," adding that they now value "personal space, self-respect, and setting boundaries."

Fashion and Aesthetics: Several respondents mentioned changes in clothing choices (e.g., baggy clothes, Korean fashion), makeup, and general aesthetics as areas of K-Pop or Western influence.

Language and Entertainment: Some respondents mentioned learning Korean through K-Pop engagement, watching Korean dramas, or adopting Western-style confidence in self-presentation.

4.7.2 How Bangladeshi Youth Can Maintain Cultural Balance

Open-ended responses to this question showed a range of awareness and engagement. The dominant theme across substantive responses was selective adoption — the idea that Bangladeshi youth should take positive elements from global cultures without abandoning their own roots. Representative responses include:

"Bangladeshi youth can maintain cultural balance by accepting positive parts of global culture without forgetting their own roots and values. They can enjoy K-pop, Western music, fashion, or lifestyle while still respecting Bangladeshi traditions, family values, language, and social responsibilities. The main thing is to take inspiration, not blindly copy everything."

"They should respect their roots; it is not suitable to follow only Western culture."

"Thorough adopting positive aspects of global culture without forgetting their cultural identity and heritage."

"Keeping everything balanced and knowing what to do based on situations, surroundings, and environment."

Some respondents recommended treating global culture purely as entertainment — a boundary that separates enjoyment from identity adoption. One noteworthy response reflected

genuine personal confidence: "I like the way I am and I don't feel uncomfortable balancing different cultures. It's not necessary to always be overly open just to follow a culture." This response embodies what Hall (1990) described as active identity negotiation rather than passive cultural absorption.

4.7.3 Additional Thoughts

The additional comments section revealed further depth of reflection. Particularly significant was one respondent's concern about religious identity: "Western culture and K-pop culture can sometimes distance us from our religious teachings, so this is something we should be careful about. Nowadays, many children of the Alpha Generation are becoming deeply influenced by these cultures, which may become a challenge for future generations if there are no proper limits." This echoes broader academic concerns about cultural globalization's interaction with religious identity in Muslim-majority societies.

Several respondents emphasized individual autonomy and non-judgmentalism: "People shouldn't be judgemental and let people live their life on their own choice. Everyone is different." Others offered balanced assessments: "Global culture has both positive and negative effects. It helps young people learn new ideas and lifestyles, but they should also respect and preserve their own culture and traditions."

5. Discussion

The findings of this study paint a nuanced picture of how K-Pop and Western culture influence Bangladeshi youth identity. Rather than a simple narrative of cultural imperialism eroding local identity, the data suggest a more complex process of selective cultural engagement, identity negotiation, and growing awareness of the need for balance.

The moderate level of consumption — with half of respondents engaging for less than one hour daily — challenges any assumption that Bangladeshi youth are overwhelmed by foreign cultural content. Most are familiar with K-Pop, but the majority are not dedicated fans. They watch, listen, and observe without necessarily constructing their identities primarily around these cultural forms. This aligns with what Appadurai (1996) termed the "work of imagination" — the active, selective process by which individuals in globalized contexts appropriate cultural elements for their own purposes.

The high agreement (75.5%) that global culture promotes open-mindedness reflects a genuine positive valuation of cross-cultural exposure. Similarly, the 58% who report being motivated to learn new languages or skills, and the 67.3% who report career/study-abroad influence, suggest that global culture serves as an aspirational horizon — broadening the scope of what young Bangladeshis see as possible for themselves. These are meaningful empowering effects that align with Hall's (1990) emphasis on identity as a site of creative self-construction.

At the same time, the study surfaces real concerns. The 62% who believe foreign culture negatively affects respect for elders points to a significant perceived threat to the hierarchical social norms central to Bangladeshi society. The intergenerational tension is reinforced by the finding that 56.2% of parents do not support their children's interest in foreign culture. These dynamics suggest that cultural globalization is not only a matter of personal identity but also a source of family and community-level stress.

The finding that 54% believe global culture causes youth to forget their roots, while simultaneously 85.7% affirm the need for cultural balance, is particularly revealing. It suggests that Bangladeshi youth are themselves aware of and concerned about the cultural risks of globalization, even as they participate in it. This self-reflexive awareness — the recognition that cultural balance is desirable and necessary — represents a form of cultural resilience rather than passive vulnerability. It also reflects the concept of "cultural hybridity" (Bhabha, 1994):

identities that are neither wholly traditional nor wholly global but dynamically composed of multiple influences.

The qualitative data deepen this picture further. Responses about maintaining cultural balance consistently emphasized selective adoption of positive elements from global culture while maintaining core local values. The recurring motif of "taking inspiration, not blindly copying" suggests that many respondents have developed a thoughtful, agency-based relationship with global cultural influences. This is consistent with the sociological understanding that globalization does not produce cultural homogenization but rather new forms of cultural negotiation and hybridization.

Finally, the role of social media — with 57.1% reporting occasional lifestyle influence — underlines the importance of digital literacy and critical media education. As platforms like TikTok and Instagram continue to evolve as powerful agents of cultural transmission, equipping Bangladeshi youth with the tools to engage with global culture critically and selectively will be increasingly important.

6. Conclusion

This study examined the influence of K-Pop and Western culture on the identity of Bangladeshi youth through a survey of 50 respondents at Eastern University and beyond. The findings reveal a population that is aware of and engaged with global cultural flows, yet remains grounded in local identity and largely committed to the principle of cultural balance. K-Pop and Western culture exert real influences on fashion, language, confidence, career aspirations, and openness — but these influences are mediated by personal agency, family context, and a strong sense of cultural roots.

The study identifies both opportunities and challenges. The positive dimensions — greater open-mindedness, motivation to learn, and expanded aspirations — suggest that thoughtful engagement with global culture can be genuinely enriching for Bangladeshi youth. The challenges — risks to cultural rootedness, intergenerational conflict, declining respect for social norms, and academic distraction — call for attention from educators, families, and community leaders.

The near-universal endorsement of cultural balance (85.7%) offers a hopeful note. Bangladeshi youth are not passive victims of cultural globalization; they are active, reflective agents negotiating complex cultural landscapes. Nurturing this reflective capacity — through critical media literacy programs, culturally responsive education, and intergenerational dialogue — seems the most promising path toward enabling young Bangladeshis to benefit from global culture while remaining firmly connected to their own heritage.

This study is limited by its convenience sample, its focus on a single educational institution, and its cross-sectional design. Future research should employ larger and more diverse samples, longitudinal methods, and comparative approaches across different regions of Bangladesh and different socioeconomic backgrounds. Qualitative in-depth interviews would provide richer insight into the lived experiences of cultural negotiation among Bangladeshi youth.

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